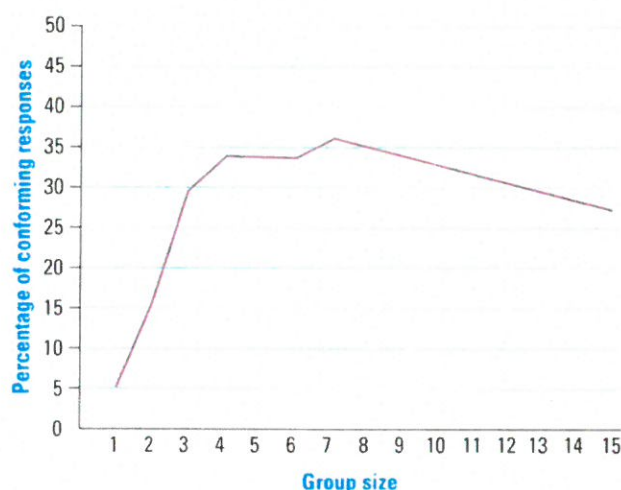


in a smaller group, an individual may think that each member of the group is behaving independently.

This latter view may be more influential on whether a conforming response is made. Consequently, a belief that one, two or three independent thinkers have reached the same answer may have a more powerful effect than a belief that 14 people are mindlessly 'doing as the others do'. In sum, group size seems to be an important factor influencing conformity, but probably only up to a point.



**Figure 9.24** Conformity increases with group size up to about four, but beyond that, group size tends to have little influence on conformity.

## Unanimity

Imagine yourself in Asch's experiment when everyone in the group gives the same answer, but an answer that is different from your answer; that is, there is **unanimity**, or complete agreement, among the other group members as to what the answer is. Would you be willing to disagree with everyone else if you believed that they were all incorrect? The results of Asch's experiment indicate that it is difficult to be a minority of one, to stand against the group, even when you think you are right and everyone else is wrong.

However, Asch also found that it takes only one person to disagree with the group's judgement to significantly affect conformity. When he allowed one confederate to answer in the same way as the research participant, the amount of conformity reduced by about 80%.

Experiments by other psychologists who subsequently investigated this *ally effect* have found that when research participants are led to believe that their thoughts, feelings or behaviour are supported, shared or not disagreed with by someone else in their group, even when everyone else in the group agrees with a different view, the presence of the ally leads to a reduction in the level of conformity. The presence of an ally who shares one's view, or at least doesn't accept the views of the majority, can be seen as providing social support that strengthens resistance to conformity.



**Figure 9.25** A group's unanimity creates pressure to conform, but it takes only one individual to disagree with the group's judgement to significantly affect conformity.



## Informational influence

In other experiments on conformity, psychologists have found that individuals are more likely to conform to the views of group members when they want to provide a correct response but they are unsure about what the correct response is. For example, suppose that you want to buy a car and have narrowed your preferences down to two cars, a red car and a purple car. They are both about the same price but have some different features. You don't know much about cars so you seek advice from a friend who does. Your friend checks both cars and recommends that you buy the purple one because it has lower kilometres on the odometer, the tyres are less worn, the registration will take longer to expire and the engine runs more smoothly.

If you accepted your friend's recommendation, then you would be conforming because information they provided influenced you to make a specific choice. In this case, you were motivated to make the right choice, viewed your friend as a valuable source of information that you lacked, then were guided by the information your friend provided when deciding what to do. **Informational influence** occurs when conformity results from a need for direction and information on how to respond in a specific situation.

Informational influence leads people to accept other people's views when they are uncertain about what to do. Research studies have specifically found that informational influence is more likely to lead to conformity when participants feel incompetent, when the task is difficult, or when participants are concerned about being right (Myers, 1990; Hewstone, Stroebe & Jonas, 2008). In all these situations, we may be motivated by wanting to be 'right' and access to relevant information can influence us to conform.

## Normative influence

When informational influence leads us to conform, we conform because we want to be right. When normative influence leads us to conform, we conform because we want to be liked and accepted by the group.

**Normative influence** to conform occurs when our response in a group situation is guided by one or more social norms. When we are aware of social norms for a particular situation, awareness of these norms can be a powerful influence on both the likelihood that we will conform and the strength of conformity that occurs.

According to psychologists, this is partly explained by our desire to be liked and accepted by other people, as well as our concern with being rejected by others. We also like to receive praise and

approval from others, particularly from those who are important in our lives, such as friends, parents, teachers and employers.

A useful way of meeting these needs for acceptance and approval is to be (or appear to be), as similar to others as possible (Hewstone, Stroebe & Jonas, 2008). From a very young age, at home and at school in particular, we learn that agreeing with other people and behaving as they do when the situation demands it usually brings positive results – people are more likely to like us and accept us, and may even give us praise or approval when we conform.

## Culture

Asch's experiment using the line-judgement task has been repeated by researchers in many different countries and cultures throughout the world. Sometimes it has been repeated in exactly the same way and at other times it has been repeated with variations; for example, by using patterns rather than lines or participants of different social backgrounds, such as gender, age and educational qualifications.

### Bond and Smith research

When British psychologists Rod Bond and Peter Smith (1996) examined the results of 133 of these 'Asch-type' experiments that have been conducted in 17 different countries, they found differences in conformity. As shown in table 9.4, conformity occurred less often in studies conducted in North America and Western Europe (for example, France and Portugal) than in other parts of the world such as Africa, Fiji and Asia (for example, Hong Kong and Japan).

Bond and Smith believe that the results of their 'meta-analysis' study suggest that there are cultural differences in conformity. The lowest conformity occurred in individualist cultures (such as North America and Western Europe). In *individualist cultures*, being an individual and independent is valued and encouraged, and achieving personal goals is considered to be more important than achieving group goals. In these cultures, it is also considered acceptable for the individual to place achievement of personal goals ahead of achieving group goals. Furthermore, those who maintain independence and resist group pressure are viewed as strong-minded and regarded more positively than those who conform. Consequently, conformity to incorrect answers given by the group in an Asch-type experiment would tend to be regarded as undesirable and weak.

The highest level of conformity occurred in collectivist cultures (such as those found in some Asian and African countries). In *collectivist cultures*, achieving group goals is considered to be more



important than the achievement of individual goals, and individuals are encouraged, and sometimes expected, to place group goals ahead of their personal goals. These cultures also encourage uniformity ('everyone being like everyone else') and values and beliefs that promote conformity and 'fitting in' for the good of the wider community, rather than individuality. Consequently, conformity to incorrect answers given by a group of confederates in an Asch-type experiment would tend to be regarded as appropriate (Bond & Smith, 1996; Smith & Bond, 1998).

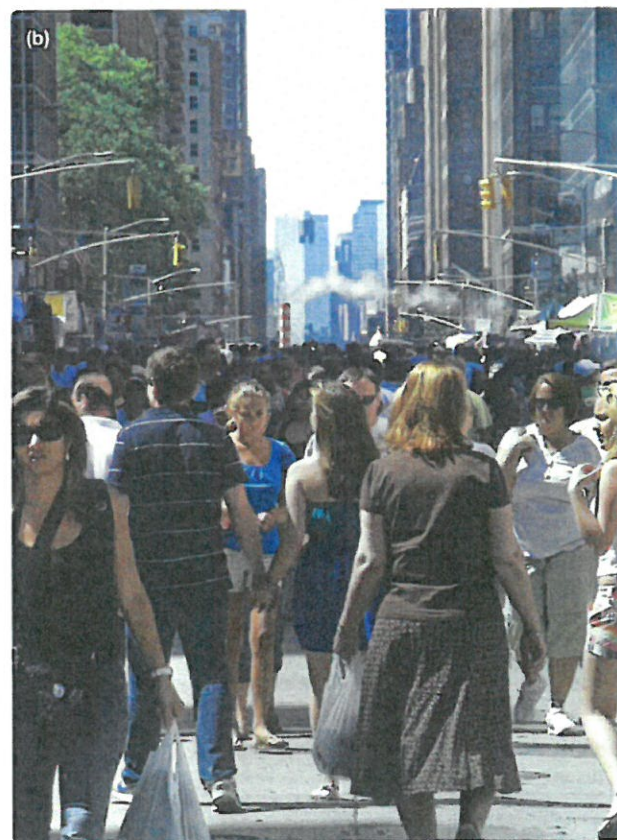
**Table 9.4** Results of Asch-type conformity studies across different cultures associated with different countries or regions

| Nation                                                  | Number of studies | Averaged effect size |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|----------------------|
| Asch's USA studies                                      | 18                | 1.16                 |
| Other USA studies                                       | 79                | 0.90                 |
| Canada                                                  | 1                 | 1.37                 |
| UK                                                      | 10                | 0.81                 |
| Belgium                                                 | 4                 | 0.94                 |
| France                                                  | 2                 | 0.56                 |
| Netherlands                                             | 1                 | 0.74                 |
| Germany                                                 | 1                 | 0.92                 |
| Portugal                                                | 1                 | 0.58                 |
| Japan                                                   | 5                 | 1.42                 |
| Brazil                                                  | 3                 | 1.60                 |
| Fiji                                                    | 2                 | 2.48                 |
| Hong Kong                                               | 1                 | 1.93                 |
| Arab samples (Kuwait, Lebanon)                          | 2                 | 1.31                 |
| Africa (Zimbabwe, Republic of the Congo (Zaire), Ghana) | 3                 | 1.84                 |

The averaged effect size in the right-hand column is the result of a statistical procedure to allow the results of Asch-type studies to be combined and averaged across different studies. The smaller the effect size, the lower the conformity, and the greater the effect size, the higher the conformity.

Source: Smith P. B. & Bond M. H. (1998). *Social Psychology Across Cultures* (2nd ed.). Boston, Massachusetts: Allyn & Bacon, p. 16.

**Figure 9.26** Conformity can be influenced by cultural norms: (a) collectivist cultures such as that found in Japan tend to be more conformist; (b) individualist cultures like the USA tend to be less conformist.





## Social loafing

Sometimes the presence of others in a group situation results in reduced performance, especially when the other people are co-workers. This reduction in the effort of an individual member of the group as a result of the presence of others results in social loafing.

**Social loafing** refers to the tendency of an individual to make less effort when involved in a group activity than when working alone. It was first systematically studied and observed in a tug-of-war experiment involving two teams of eight people. The results showed that the collective effort exerted by each team did not match the total of the individual efforts. For example, blindfolded participants who were assigned the first position in the tug-of-war machine (see figure 9.27) and told to 'pull as hard as you can' pulled 18 per cent harder when they knew they were pulling alone than when they believed that others were also pulling (Ingham et al., 1974).

In the laboratory, social loafing has been observed among people in a variety of situations such as rope-pulling (tug-of-war), shouting and clapping, pumping water or air, writing poems or editorials, producing ideas and typing. However, most of these studies were conducted with American and European participants. Research on social loafing using Chinese participants has found that participants work harder in a group situation than when they work alone. This finding indicates a cultural difference in social loafing (Moghaddam, Taylor & Wright, 1993).



**Figure 9.27** This tug-of-war apparatus was used in the experiment by Ingham et al. (1974). Participants in the first position did not pull as hard when they thought that people behind them were also pulling.

Social loafing can also be observed in everyday life situations. For example, some workers who do not pay for membership of a union are social loafers if they accept the improved benefits for workers achieved by the union.

Generally, social loafers conform to their group, but with less effort. This is based on their belief that conforming (or not conforming) will not make much of a difference in what the group decides (or does), so they just go along with whatever the group agrees to do (or does).

The influence of social loafing on conformity can depend on many different factors. Experimental research findings indicate that people are less likely to 'loaf' in groups when the group consists of friends rather than strangers, but this depends on the extent to which the group's decision or behaviour is of importance to the individual. For example an individual is less likely to conform through social loafing when they view their group's outcome as important, challenging or appealing.



**Figure 9.28** Conformity by social loafing is eliminated entirely when maximum effort from individual members of a group is essential for the group's goal to be attained.

American psychologists Steven Karau and Kipling Williams (1993) analysed the findings of 78 research studies on social loafing and found that social loafing is less likely to influence conformity, if at all, when:

- maximum effort from everyone in the group is essential for the group's goal to be attained
- the group is valued by its members (for example, the group is made up of close friends)
- the task is important, challenging or appealing to those performing it
- the group is small
- members of a group believe that it is possible for their individual performance to be judged in some way
- other group members are not expected to perform well so social loafing might lead to failure on the task
- those working on the task are women rather than men.